

Fake YouTube Site Targets Syrian Activists With Malware

 eff.org/deeplinks/2012/03/fake-youtube-site-targets-syrian-activists-malware

By Eva Galperin and Morgan Marquis-Boire

March 15, 2012



Last week, EFF [reported](#) on two instances of pro-Syrian-government malware targeting Syrian activists through links sent in chats and emails. This week, we've seen new Windows malware dropped by a fake YouTube site hosting Syrian opposition videos.

Below is a screenshot of the fake YouTube page, which attacks users in two ways: it requires you to enter your YouTube login credentials in order to leave comments, and it installs malware disguised as an Adobe Flash Player update.

This phishing site has been taken down, but if you encounter a similar page **do not enter your YouTube login credentials to comment**. If you have already logged in to the site (or a similar site) to leave a comment **follow the steps outlined below to see if your computer has been infected, and change your YouTube and Gmail passwords from an uninfected computer immediately**. You may also wish to take [some additional steps](#) to make sure that your Gmail account is secure, including enabling 2-factor authentication and checking to see if any suspicious forwarding addresses or delegated accounts have been added to your account.

If you encounter a similar page **do not click "Install" to update Flash**. Clicking "Install" drops a file called setup.exe. This is a .NET file and .NET is required to run it. Once it is installed, the dropper connects back to an address in Syrian IP space and

downloads additional malware, which gives the attacker administrative access to your computer.

To see if you have been infected, look for the following files:

These files are "system files" and will not be visible by default. To change your settings to make system files visible in Windows 7, Start-->Control Panel-->Appearance and Personalization-->Show hidden files and folders, then select the radio button called Show Hidden Files, Folders, and Drives. Remove the checkbox labeled "Hide extensions for known file types." Remove the checkbox labeled "Hide protected operating system files."

C:\Documents and Settings\Administrator\Local Settings\Temp\sysglobl.exe

C:\Documents and Settings\Administrator\Local Settings\Temp\mscordbc.exe

On Windows 7 systems, you can find them here:

C:\Users\Administrator\AppData\Local\Temp\sysglobl.exe

C:\Users\Administrator\AppData\Local\Temp\mscordbc.exe

You can see both files in the screenshot below:

What do do if your computer is infected:

If your computer is infected, deleting the above files does not guarantee that your computer will be safe or secure. This attack eventually gives an attacker the ability to execute arbitrary code on the infected computer. There is no guarantee that the attacker has not installed additional malicious software while in control of the machine. The safest course of action is to re-install the operating system on your computer and change all passwords to accounts you may have logged into while the computer was infected.

EFF is deeply concerned about this pattern of pro-government malware targeting online activists in authoritarian regimes. We will continue to keep a close eye on future developments in this area.

Related Issues

Tags

Related Updates



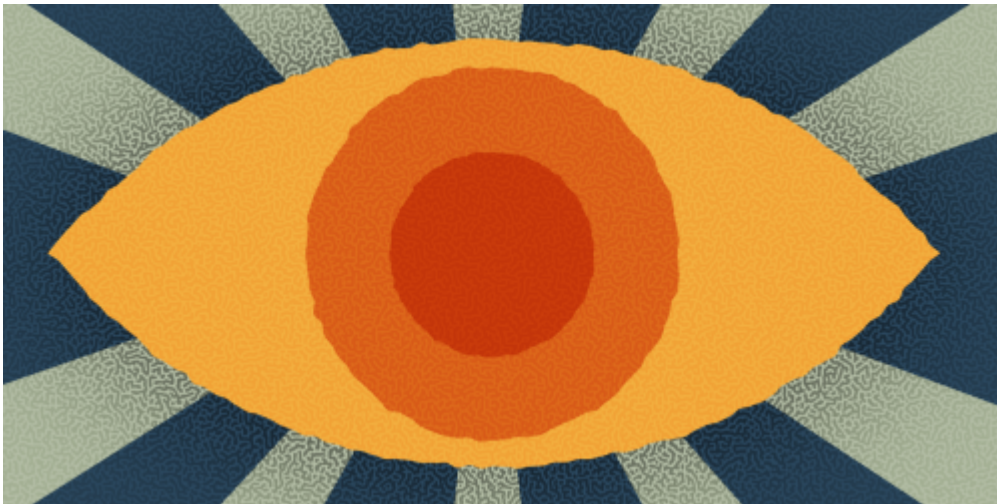
[EFF and ARTICLE 19 Submission to the European Commission on the DSA Trusted Flagger Guidelines](#)

EFF and [ARTICLE 19](#) have submitted joint comments to the European Commission on [draft guidelines](#) for the Digital Services Act's trusted flagger mechanism. Having long advocated for a DSA that protects freedom of expression while preserving intermediary liability protections and the prohibition on general monitoring, we welcome the...



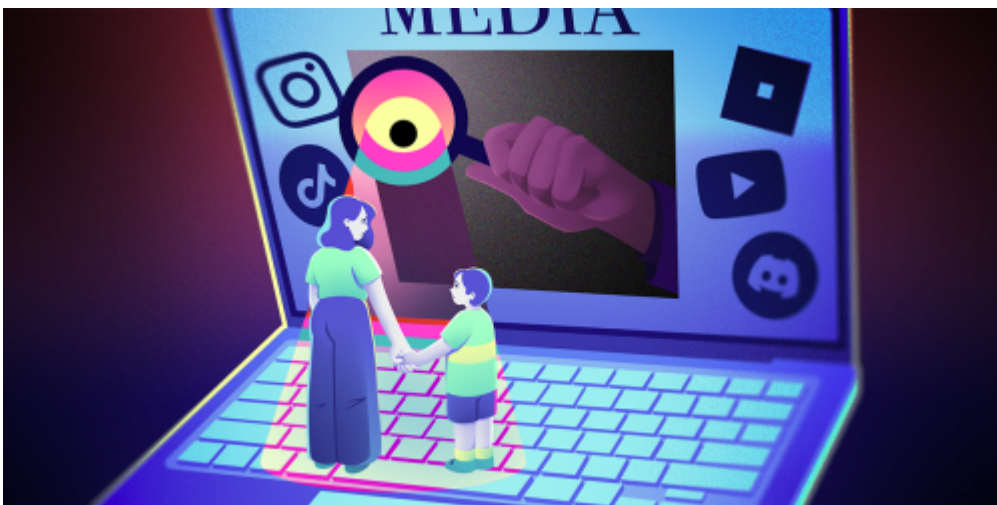
[European Commission Chooses to Keep EU Users Locked Up Behind Big Tech's Gates](#)

Users are always seeking more control over their social networking experience to make it better, whether to improve privacy or enhance flexibility. Interoperability between social networking platforms like Facebook and TikTok has so many benefits that solve those issues. Say you're on multiple platforms because you have friends you follow...



[EFF, TEDIC and CEJIL Challenge Secrecy in the Use of Face Recognition in Paraguay](#)

Seeking transparency and accountability in Paraguay's use of facial recognition, EFF, the Association of Technology, Education, Development, Research, Communication (TEDIC), and the Centre for Justice and International Law (CEJIL) filed a complaint with the Inter-American Commission on Human Rights against the state for arbitrarily denying access to information about its...



[Internet Age Gates Are a Growing Global Threat](#)

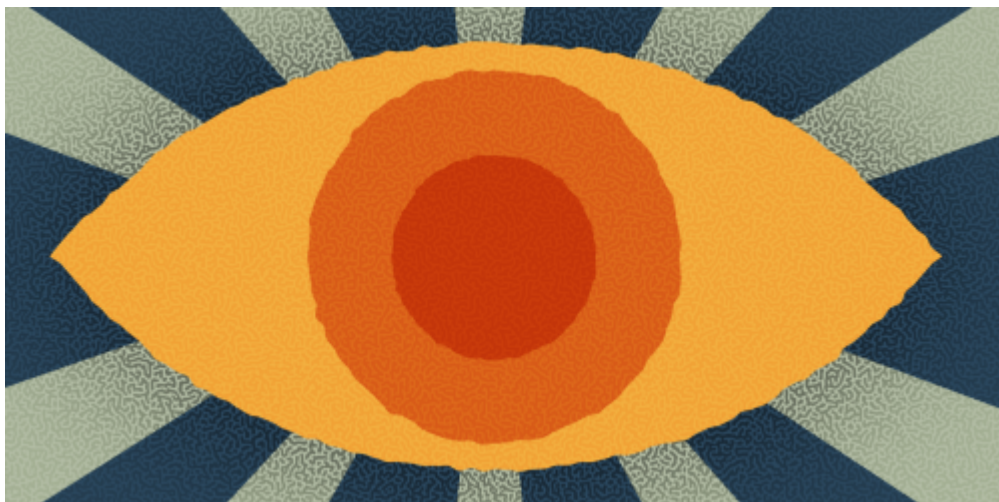
The internet is an essential resource for young people and adults to access information, explore community, and find themselves—both inside countries and across continents. Yet governments around the world continue to introduce and implement legislation requiring all online users to verify their ages before accessing the digital space.



[Deeplinks Blog](#) by [Betty Gedlu](#), Cindy Cohn | May 19, 2026

[Microsoft Took a Step Toward Human Rights Accountability. Google and Amazon \(and Others\) Should Pay Attention!](#)

For years, civil society organizations, workers, journalists, and human rights experts have warned that major technology companies risk enabling grave human rights abuses when they provide cloud computing, AI, and surveillance infrastructure to governments implicated in violations of international and humanitarian law. While many companies pay lip service to evaluating...



[We Must Not Normalize Digital Surveillance Abuses. EFF's New Guide Underlines Concrete Steps to Fight Back.](#)

Poor accountability, feeble control mechanisms, and insufficient legal frameworks have led to systematic human rights violations in the Americas, with no consistent remedy or reparation to victims. What's needed is to materialize essential guarantees and measures to combat repeated surveillance abuses in the region. To help build a path...



[EFF Launches New Offline Campaign for Saudi Wikipedian Osama Khalid](#)

Osama Khalid was just twelve years old when he began contributing to Wikipedia Arabic. In the height of the blogging era, he became a prolific blogger, publishing writings on his home country of Saudi Arabia, meetups he attended, and his opinions and observations about open source technology and freedom of...



[A Hackers Guide to Circumventing Internet Shutdowns](#)

Internet shutdowns are devastating for human rights. We can't rely on tech oligarchs to save us, especially when these same companies and governments are the ones to sever our access to the internet and telecommunications. This is why it's important to set up communication mechanisms before a disaster happens.



[Deeplinks Blog](#) by Electronic Frontier Foundation | May 11, 2026

[EFF Stands in Solidarity With RightsCon and the Global Digital Rights Community](#)

The abrupt cancellation of RightsCon 2026—the world's largest annual global digital rights conference—is not just a logistical disruption for thousands of participants—it is part of a growing global pattern of shrinking civic space and increasing hostility toward free expression and independent civil society.



EFF and 18 Organizations Urge UK Policymakers to Prioritize Addressing the Roots of Online Harm

EFF joins 18 organizations in writing a letter to UK policymakers urging them to address the root causes of online harm—rather than undermining the open web through blunt restrictions.